ELITE

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ELITE

FOUNDATIONS

This document is not a training program.
It is a guide to becoming an Archange Expurgateur.

I. Process Above All

Chasing mass, watching nutrition, counting calories down to the gram — all of it is necessary, all of it is good.

The body is the tool. And like any tool, it is perfected through use, not through contemplation.

The problem is not wanting results. The problem is fixating on them to the point of becoming blind to the only place where everything actually happens : *the process.*

What you observe today in the mirror, in your performance, in your body — is the fruit of what you did before.

Not what you do now. What you do now will bear fruit later, gradually, according to a logic that has no patience for impatience.

It is thankless work. Work to be put back to the bench again and again.

You would like to see, you would like the gesture and its effect to coincide — but the body does not work in the instant. It accumulates, it integrates, it answers in delay.

All your attention must therefore be placed on performance as process — not as result, not as objective. On what happens between the moment you touch the bar and the moment you put it back down.

« The result is the consequence of the process. »

II. The Greatest Lie of Coaching

You have surely been told to set attainable goals. Realistic goals. Small milestones to stay motivated.

This is the standard discourse of the coaching industry.

It is marketing. Designed so that the client stays content, pays his monthly fee without ever truly facing the effort, the doubt — without ever facing the real power of his becoming.

Attainable goals are made to « relieve » you. In reality, you do not need to be relieved.

I will go further : the moment you can no longer bear the tension, you stop progressing.

I have never seen a coach truly do his work. There is only one job to do, and they all get it wrong.

They think their work is to write a program, correct technique, give advice. All of that is superfluous.

The only true work is to refuse to yield on the demands.

Remember who you are. Discover your destiny.

III. The Violence of Change

Change is violence. Not metaphorically — biologically and psychically.

The body, like the psyche, operates on the principle of least effort. They spend energy only when forced to.

Left to themselves, they maintain what they already know. They resist anything that costs.

Change does not consist of adapting the environment to oneself. It is exactly the opposite : it is oneself who must adapt to something one is given to do and was not capable of doing.

A super-adaptation. A transformation.

This program exists precisely to force that transformation. That is its whole essence.

Whether in training or in diet, every session, every meal, every choice is an injunction addressed to the body and the psyche to fully embrace the potential of what they may become.

That potential is not to be built — it is already there, buried beneath resistances, habits, inherited fears. It must be uncovered.

Wo Es war, soll Ich werden.

« Where Id was, there Ego shall be. » — Sigmund Freud

IV. Your Real Potential

Think about stretching.

When you try to go further into a split, you feel resistance — a limit. But that is not your real limit.

It is your nervous system activating a protective reflex : it contracts the muscles to keep you from going any further.

It is not your body that cannot — it is your body that refuses.

There is an observation that everyone has made without drawing the lesson : a drunk person is far more flexible. Not because alcohol lengthens the tendons — but because it inhibits the protective reflex.

The limiter is disabled.

This is obviously not advice to train heavy after a few drinks. It is a demonstration that your limit is not where you think it is — it is in what prevents you from reaching

it.

With strength, it is exactly the same. Session after session, you realize that you can lift heavier, do more reps — where you would have sworn it was impossible.

What you believe to be your limit is a perceived limit, not a real one.

There is a popular legend of the mother who sees her child trapped under a car and, alone, lifts it to free him. One could believe it a myth — and yet, several cases are documented.

In 1982, Angela Cavallo lifted a Chevrolet Impala weighing nearly 1700 kilos to save her son. In 2019, a sixteen-year-old boy lifted a Volkswagen Passat weighing a ton to free a neighbor. Other cases exist.

This phenomenon has a name : *hysterical strength*.

Under the effect of adrenaline and extreme stress, the « central governor » — that nervous mechanism which permanently bridles your force to preserve your tissues — switches off. The body accesses a strength it did not know it had.

And these people, often, come away with injuries — because the power they mobilized exceeded what their own tissues could withstand.

This is your real potential. And this is what you must remember at training.

The body is capable of infinitely more than what it shows — but it protects itself, because it knows it is fragile.

The first work, then, is the work of *renforcement*, in the full sense : being robust enough to support your own strength. Soft tissues, ligaments, tendons, skin, fascia.

Without that work, the strength released becomes a danger to the one who produces it.

V. Intention — The Key to Everything

What triggers the body to operate at its full potential is not the program. It is not nutrition, nor equipment.

It is intention.

Intention is what makes the difference between missing a rep and pushing six. Between doing an exercise and *truly* doing it. Between training and transforming.

Every set demands total presence — not because it deserves it, but because without it, the set does not produce what it must produce. It is not optional. It is necessary.

Intention is built. It is not innate, it is not reserved for champions. It is a skill — and like any skill, it requires work on the self that goes beyond the gym.

To go further on intention and the psychology of performance, supervision on parlaforce.com connects you with a psychologist specialized in strength sports. This work is the direct complement of this program.

VI. The Indomitable Desire

There is a force in you more powerful than will, more powerful than discipline, more powerful than any method : *desire*.

Real desire — not passing wants, not the enthusiasm of Monday morning — the deep desire, the one that does not negotiate, the one that knows no ceiling.

Many people believe they have needs to satisfy. That at such-and-such a level of performance, such a silhouette, such a number on the bar, something will finally be reached, finally appeased.

No.

Desire is not a need. A need is filled. Desire is always ahead.

You will always be hungry. Life is a one-way ticket. Knife between the teeth, and bon voyage.

But most people have no access to that desire. Not because it is not there. But because it is *bridled.*

By upbringing, by accumulated neuroses, by inherited fears, by the superego — that instance which sets limits on what you have the right to want, on what you have the right to be.

The work of this program, combined with the supervision, aims to free that desire — not toward an arrival point, but in its very movement, always forward.

Be warned : the effects of this work are not limited to training. No domain of your life comes out unchanged.

« Desire is not filled. It is freed. »

VII. The Inner Enemy

You have probably heard someone say — or said it yourself :

« I don't want to get too muscular. »
« I'm not aiming for a competition-level performance. »
« It's fine, I just want to feel good. »

These phrases sound reasonable. They are not. They are protection mechanisms.

Freud called this the *superego* — that instance which sets limits on what you have the right to be and on what you have the right to want.

There is something deeper still. Many people need idols — superhuman athletes, untouchable champions.

These figures play a reassuring role : they keep watch. They are at the top in our place. And as long as they are there, we can sleep easy telling ourselves that someone truly strong exists somewhere.

But what if you became that strong one ? You would lose that security. You could no longer idolize.

You would have to fully assume what you are — without a tutelary figure, without a champion to look up to from below.

And that is what scares people. Not the effort. Not the pain. The responsibility of the one who has no excuse left.

There is another form of the same mechanism, more insidious. People calculate the cost of the effort and try to see whether the results are worth it.

But if you calculate without having walked through the door, it never is.

And this principle applies to absolutely everything in life. Nothing is « worth it ». Every cost is greater in itself.

But to think this way is to despise human nature.

You don't do something for a benefit. The benefit, the result, is another story — and it is a story told *afterwards*.

You do things because you want to do them. The central point is there, and there is no other.

As long as you are still measuring, you are standing still.

This entire guide exists to encourage movement. Not to justify making it.

This program asks you to accept that. To want to become truly strong. Not « strong for your age ». Not « strong for someone who trains at home ».

Strong. Period.

VIII. Steady Wins the Race

A world-class champion can train in a backyard.

Not because equipment is irrelevant — but because what makes a champion is *consistency*, *intention*, and *time*.

Things that life can take from you — and it will try. That is precisely why they have value.

Add a kilo when you can. Regularly. Inexorably.

In two years, in five years : you will look back and not recognize the numbers on the bar. That is progress in the long term.

The temptation will always be the same : do more, go faster, add a session, switch programs, look for the secret method.

Resist.

What works best is the simplest — applied with absolute rigor, day after day, for years.

Trust the process. Steady wins the race.

IX. Recovery — The Silent Weapon

Recovery is not a reward. It is part of training.

Transformation happens during rest — not during the session. The session is the stimulus. The rest is adaptation.

The number-one factor of recovery — every coach and every elite athlete knows it : stress management, psychology, emotions.

Everyone knows it. And yet, almost no one goes to therapy. This is the perfect demonstration that *knowledge brings nothing on its own.*

You can know that something is essential and do nothing. Only experience transforms.

Supervision on parlaforce.com is precisely that : working with a psychologist specialized in strength sports, to turn knowledge into lived experience.

The basics, applied seriously, surpass any sophisticated protocol :

— Hydrate massively. Water is the first ergogenic.

— Sleep. This is when tissues repair and the nervous system recovers.

— Walk for at least 45 minutes every day — weighted for maximum benefit.

— Eat full and clean. Alternate surplus and deficit — the body adapts to everything, including abundance. Periodize your nutrition as you periodize your loads.

Deload

It is not owed — it is earned. If you never feel the need for a lighter week, you are not training for real.

In the beginning, you will learn to recognize it — to distinguish laziness from real fatigue.

With time, when you have become an advanced athlete, you will know exactly when to schedule it for maximum benefit. That is what *interpreting your body* means.

You often hear « listen to your body ». It is the favorite line of those who took up sport at fifty to justify stopping precisely where it starts to count.

« I listen to my body » — meaning : *I stop when it gets hard.*

But that is exactly when the work begins.

Many patients say : « it can't be normal, after my squats I felt like I was about to pass out. » World champions, themselves, organize every session to reach precisely that state.

When you feel you are about to pass out : *the effort is there.*

The real formula is not to listen — it is to interpret.

Knowing the difference between what stops you because it is necessary and what stops you because it is comfortable.

That, too, is something you can train — and that is exactly what supervision is for.

Soreness

Soreness is not a good sign.

There is a widespread belief — « if I'm sore, it means I trained well » — and it is wrong.

If you feel it strongly, it is in fact a rather bad sign.

Soreness is the sign that you attempted an adaptation you were not yet ready for. Whether a new exercise, a new volume, or a new degree of intensity.

The body tried to absorb something beyond what it knew how to handle — and it paid the price with inflammation, micro-tears, and all the discomfort that follows.

This is why novelty must be introduced gradually.

When you add a new exercise, start with very low volume — a single set, light load. Increase only if the previous session went without excessive soreness.

When you increase intensity, do it in small increments — no leaps forward.

A well-trained athlete, progressing regularly within his usual frame, should rarely feel soreness anymore.

The absence of soreness is not the sign that you are not training. It is the sign that your body has integrated what you ask of it.

ELITE

PRACTICAL GUIDELINES

Being an Archange Expurgateur in daily life.

I. The Wake-Up — Anchoring the Cycle

Wake up at the same time every day.

Research on circadian rhythm clearly establishes that this is what anchors the biological clock — not the time you go to bed.

Sleep onset follows naturally according to the recovery needs of the night.

As soon as you wake : open your eyes and expose yourself to natural light immediately.

Inside the retina are particular ganglion cells — the *ipRGCs* — which contain a photopigment called *melanopsin*.

These cells play no role in vision : their sole function is to detect ambient light and send a direct signal to the suprachiasmatic nucleus, the master clock of the brain.

This signal triggers melatonin suppression, initiates the morning cortisol peak, and synchronizes all peripheral clocks of the body.

It is the daily *reset* of the system. Without it, the cycle drifts.

A note on sleep, before going further : it is the best recovery tool that exists. More powerful than any protocol. More powerful than doping.

During sleep, GH is secreted massively, tissues repair, motor memory consolidates, the central nervous system recovers.

We will return to it at the end of the day — in its rightful place.

II. Hydration — The First Act

After a night of sleep, the body is dehydrated.

The first move is to drink. Not coffee — water.

Water makes up 50 to 70 % of total body mass. Every physiological process depends on it : muscle contraction, protein synthesis, thermoregulation, nutrient transport, hormonal regulation.

For every 1 % of body mass lost to dehydration, heart rate rises by about 3 beats per minute.

A loss above 2 % significantly compromises performance.

And thirst ? It is a late signal. By the time you are thirsty, you are already behind.

The numbers : minimum 3 to 3.5 liters per day for an active man, more on training days.

Drink frequently, in small regular amounts, throughout the day.

Simple and reliable indicator : urine color. Very pale yellow to clear — hydration is correct. Deep yellow — dehydration is already in place.

III. Nutrition — The Truth About Meals

The dogma of the 90s was definitive : six small meals a day, no more than 30g of absorbable protein per meal.

It is false, and that idea wasted a lot of time for a lot of people.

The anabolic signal of a meal is mainly triggered by *leucine* — an essential amino acid that activates the mTORC1 pathway, the main anabolic cascade in skeletal muscle.

What matters is not the number of meals, but the quality and the strength of the signal generated at each meal.

A meal rich in complete proteins and leucine produces a plasma peak that efficiently triggers muscle protein synthesis.

Eating fewer meals, but truly eating them — with enough protein, enough carbs, enough leucine — is more effective.

It is also far easier to sustain over time.

The window around the session

This is where nutrition becomes strategic.

Pre-session, the goal is twofold : provide available glycogen and create a favorable hormonal environment.

Carbs of moderate to high glycemic index, some protein, minimal fat to speed gastric emptying. 60 to 90 minutes before the session.

Don't train fasted if performance is the goal — glycogen is the fuel of intense effort.

Post-session, the anabolic window is real but far wider than previously believed : several hours, not 30 minutes.

The goal is to provide leucine-rich proteins to trigger muscle synthesis, carbs to restore glycogen, and to temporarily limit fats which slow absorption.

IV. The Macros — Real Numbers

Protein : 1.6g per kg of bodyweight, in all phases — surplus, maintenance, deficit. No more.

The idea that you must drastically increase protein during a deficit to save muscle is a persistent error.

What protects muscle in a deficit is not extra protein — it is carbs.

Sufficient carbs maintain glycogen, preserve lean mass, sustain strength and energy at the session.

Raising protein at the expense of carbs during a cut means stripping yourself of fuel while trying to perform. *It is incoherent.*

Fats : 0.8 to 1.2g/kg in maintenance and surplus. 0.8g/kg minimum in deficit.

Fats are essential to hormone production — cholesterol is the direct precursor of all steroid hormones, including testosterone.

Dropping them too low compromises the hormonal axis.

Carbs : the rest of the calories, after protein and fats are set. The most flexible macro and the most important for performance.

Calories — surplus : TDEE + 200 kcal. No more.

A surplus of 200 or 2,000 calories produces the same amount of muscle, but with 2,000 of surplus the excess turns into fat. Better to be precise.

Deficit : TDEE - 200 to 300 kcal maximum.

Going too slowly is far better than going too fast : too slowly means you only lose fat and only build muscle — no negative effect.

Going too fast means losing muscle and sometimes even gaining fat.

V. Cycles — Surplus, Maintenance, Deficit

What we would like is to be in a caloric surplus all the time. It is comfortable : maximum carbs, energy overflowing, performance climbing without resistance.

But the body adapts to everything.

Held too long in surplus, it adapts — insulin sensitivity drops, body composition slowly degrades, and weight gain stops being mostly muscular.

Even for an athlete who has « no fat to lose » — and let's be honest, after a long surplus there is always some — the body must periodically be unconditioned.

That is exactly the function of a caloric deficit.

The worst thing one can do is go too fast. In losing as in gaining.

Going too fast in losing means burning muscle for a bit more fat lost. Going too fast in gaining means storing fat for a bit more muscle gained. In both cases, the ratio is bad.

The Deficit

0.6 to 0.8 % of bodyweight lost per week. This is the optimal documented zone for preserving lean mass and strength while losing fat.

Slower is needlessly long. Faster, and you start paying in muscle and energy.

Duration : 6 to 12 weeks depending on needs.

Being hungry — good or bad sign ?

In a deficit, you will be hungry. And that is precisely what should happen — it is the sign that the cut is working.

But only if everything else is in place. Otherwise, hunger is not the signal of a working fat loss — it is the signal of a broken diet.

Here is the grid to tell the difference.

The same grid applies to other sensations that may seem alarming but are not.

For example, feeling a drop in blood pressure after a particularly demanding session — heavy squat, all-out deadlift — is *normal* if you ate well, slept well, drank well.

It is not a problem — it is the signature of an effort that truly dug deep.

On the other hand, the same drop in someone who has not eaten in four hours, who sleeps poorly and drinks too little — that is no longer the same story.

The meaning of a sensation always depends on context. The grid above serves to distinguish the two.

Maintenance

Two weeks at TDEE after each deficit.

This pause allows metabolism and hormones — leptin, thyroid hormones, testosterone — to recover from the metabolic stress of the deficit.

Skipping this stage to go straight into surplus risks a mostly fat-based weight gain, since the body is still in conservation mode.

The Surplus

0.3 to 0.5 % of bodyweight gained per week.

This is the window in which most of the gain is muscular for an intermediate or advanced athlete.

Beyond that, the extra calories convert entirely into fat, because protein synthesis is mechanically capped.

Duration : 12 to 16 weeks, then switch to a new deficit cycle.

These ranges are not negotiable — it is the mechanics of the body that impose them, not convention.

Discipline here is not in the severity of the deficit or the aggressiveness of the surplus, but in the patience to respect the rhythm.

VI. Sample Diet — Maintenance Calories

What follows is a concrete example, not a universal protocol.

It is a maintenance-calorie diet. Adapt the quantities to your bodyweight and TDEE.

2 identical main meals

— 80g raw rice

— 150g potato

— 100g ground beef 15 % fat

— 4 whole eggs

— 10g butter

— Broccoli

— Bell pepper, onion, cabbage, red cabbage

— 1 piece of fruit

	Kcal	*Protein*	*Carbs*	*Fats*
1 meal	~1,199	~61g	~145g	~40g
×2 meals	~2,398	~122g	~290g	~80g

Snack — every day

— 400g fat-free fromage blanc (or quark)

— 40g rolled oats

— 10g chia seeds

— 10g walnut halves

— 2 squares of dark chocolate

— 120g blueberries

— Generous cinnamon

	Kcal	*Protein*	*Carbs*	*Fats*
Snack	~600	~40g	~68g	~17g

Pre-session — training days only

— 2 bananas

— 30g honey

— 300ml kefir

— **Salt** — a generous pinch. Sodium is essential to neuromuscular transmission and muscle contraction. Pre-session, it promotes intramuscular water retention — better-hydrated muscle cells are cells that perform better. It also prevents cramps linked to electrolyte depletion during effort. A simple detail, a real impact.

	Kcal	*Protein*	*Carbs*	*Fats*
Pre-session	~488	~13g	~94g	~11g

Daily totals

	Kcal	*Protein*	*Carbs*	*Fats*
Training day	~3,486	~176g	~451g	~107g
Rest day	~2,998	~163g	~357g	~95g

VII. Why These Foods — Micronutrients and Hormones

Every food has a precise reason to be there. Nothing is by chance.

Beef + whole eggs

Dietary cholesterol is the direct precursor of all steroid hormones — including testosterone.

Egg yolk is one of the most bioavailable sources of exogenous cholesterol usable by the endocrine glands.

Butter amplifies that supply with cholesterol and saturated fats needed for steroidogenesis.

The zinc in beef is an indispensable cofactor in testosterone synthesis — a deficiency translates directly into a drop in androgen production.

Onion

Onion is a natural aromatase inhibitor — the enzyme that converts testosterone into estrogen.

Its sulfur compounds (allicin and derivatives) reduce that conversion and thus directly contribute to maintaining a favorable testosterone/estrogen ratio.

Its quercetin is also a powerful anti-inflammatory that protects cells against oxidative stress linked to intense effort.

Broccoli, cabbage, red cabbage

These cruciferous vegetables are rich in *indole-3-carbinol*, a phytochemical that modulates estrogen metabolism through the liver — favoring its elimination and optimizing the testosterone/estrogen ratio.

This is why crucifers belong in any serious natural strength diet.

Red cabbage deserves a special mention : it is exceptionally rich in anthocyanins — the same antioxidant pigments found in blueberries — which reduce systemic inflammation and protect blood vessels.

It also contains significant vitamin C and sulfur compounds that support liver detoxification.

Bell pepper

An exceptional source of vitamin C — more than a citrus fruit at equal weight.

Vitamin C is a cofactor in testosterone synthesis and protects Leydig cells from oxidative stress.

It also contributes to collagen synthesis, which is essential for the health of tendons and ligaments under increasing load.

Walnut halves + chia seeds

Omega-3, zinc, magnesium.

Magnesium improves deep sleep quality and insulin sensitivity.

Omega-3 reduce systemic inflammation and positively modulate body composition over the long term.

Cinnamon

Several studies converge on its effect on insulin sensitivity — it improves glucose uptake by muscle cells, optimizing the efficiency of consumed carbs and reducing post-prandial fat storage.

Kefir

It is a natural anabolic.

Kefir is a dense source of probiotics that optimize the gut-hormone axis : a healthy microbiome improves nutrient absorption, reduces intestinal inflammation, and modulates IGF-1 production.

Recent studies show that certain Lactobacillus strains present in kefir directly stimulate GH and IGF-1 secretion.

Optimal dose is between 200 and 400ml per day — 300ml is in the ideal window.

Pre-session, it also provides fast proteins, carbs, calcium and electrolytes.

Honey + banana

Mixed carbs — fructose and glucose — for fast and progressive energy availability.

Fructose preferentially restores liver glycogen, glucose restores muscle glycogen.

Together they create an optimal pre-session glycemic environment, without a brutal spike or crash.

Fat-free fromage blanc (or quark)

Casein is a slow-digesting protein.

Post-session, it provides a flow of amino acids spread over 6 to 8 hours — sustaining muscle protein synthesis well beyond the immediate window, and through sleep.

That is precisely why it is consumed daily, not only on session days.

Blueberries

Blueberries are among the most antioxidant-rich foods — particularly in *anthocyanins*, the polyphenols that give their blue color.

After intense effort, the body produces large amounts of free radicals.

If this oxidative stress is not counterbalanced, it slows recovery, raises systemic inflammation, and accelerates cellular aging.

The antioxidants in blueberries neutralize these free radicals and reduce post-effort inflammatory markers.

They also improve circulation and protect blood vessels. A generous handful per day is enough to gain the benefits.

Bone broth

Bone broth is one of the richest dietary sources of collagen.

Collagen is the main structural protein of tendons, ligaments, cartilage, and skin — exactly the tissues that adapt the slowest to intense training.

Regular bone-broth consumption provides the precursors — glycine, proline, hydroxyproline — needed for endogenous collagen synthesis.

It also provides gelatin, beneficial for joint health, and minerals like calcium, magnesium, and phosphorus drawn directly from bones during long cooking.

Rolled oats

Rolled oats are a dense source of complex carbs at a moderate glycemic index, ideal for sustaining energy without a brutal insulin spike.

Rich in magnesium, phosphorus, non-heme iron, and B vitamins, they particularly complement a diet centered on red meat and eggs.

Their fiber content — notably *beta-glucans* — plays a double role : promoting satiety and stabilizing blood sugar, but also reducing low-grade systemic inflammation, which slows recovery and gradually degrades body composition.

Beta-glucans further improve lipid profile and insulin sensitivity, two key parameters for testosterone and performance.

Key micronutrients

Four trace elements and vitamins deserve particular attention for the strength athlete.

Iron — the central component of hemoglobin and myoglobin — transports oxygen to the muscles. Intense training increases its needs through sweat and increased red blood cell production.

Beef provides heme iron, the most absorbable form. The vitamin C in bell pepper enhances its absorption — eat them at the same meal.

Zinc is involved in over 300 enzymatic reactions, directly tied to testosterone production and protein synthesis.

Beef and eggs are good sources, but dietary intake rarely covers a strength athlete's needs.

Copper is linked to iron and zinc in their function.

It is the trace element hardest to cover through modern diets — the main sources are organ meats and seafood, rarely on most plates.

A combined zinc + copper supplementation is therefore almost unavoidable.

Always as a combined complex because these two minerals compete for absorption — an excess of zinc alone mechanically creates a copper deficiency.

Vitamin B12 is essential for red blood cell production, nervous system function, and cognitive performance.

It is well covered by this diet thanks to beef and eggs — one of the advantages of an omnivorous diet dense in animal protein.

A deficiency remains possible in case of an absorption problem, independent of intake.

VIII. Supplementation

Vitamin D3

Synthesized 80–90 % by sunlight, almost impossible to cover by diet alone.

More than 50 % of elite athletes are deficient.

Direct role in testosterone, bone health, and muscle recovery.

Supplementing D3 — not D2 — is essential at temperate latitudes.

Omega-3 EPA/DHA

Walnuts and chia seeds provide ALA, a precursor of omega-3.

The problem : the body converts ALA into EPA and DHA at only about 5–10 %.

Without regularly consuming fatty fish, levels remain structurally insufficient.

EPA and DHA reduce systemic inflammation, improve insulin sensitivity, and accelerate muscle recovery.

Fish oil or algae oil.

Magnesium

Present in the diet — oats, nuts, dark chocolate — but intense training significantly increases losses through sweat.

Involved in over 300 enzymatic reactions : muscle contraction, protein synthesis, cortisol regulation.

One of the most common deficiencies in strength athletes.

Prefer bisglycinate or malate, better absorbed than oxide.

Zinc + Copper

Hard to cover with modern diets without organ meats or seafood.

Zinc participates in testosterone production and over 300 enzymatic reactions. Copper is the most systematically deficient trace element.

Always as a combined complex — an excess of zinc alone mechanically creates a copper deficiency.

Classic ratio : 15 mg zinc to 1 to 2 mg copper.

Creatine monohydrate

The diet provides no more than 1 g per day. To saturate muscle stores, an athlete needs about 0.1 g per kg of bodyweight per day.

It is the most documented supplement in the history of strength sport.

It increases strength, power, accelerates recovery, and improves body composition.

No valid argument against taking it.

Supplementation — In Brief

— **Vitamin D3** — insufficient without sun. D3 only, not D2.

— **Omega-3 EPA/DHA** — ALA does not convert. Fish or algae oil.

— **Magnesium** — losses from training. Bisglycinate or malate, not oxide.

— **Zinc + copper** — always combined. Ratio 15:1 or 15:2.

— **Creatine monohydrate** — 0.1 g per kg of bodyweight per day.

IX. Blood Test — Know Before Supplementing

Supplementing without knowing your biological status is shooting in the dark.

An annual blood test allows precise targeting of what is missing — and avoiding supplementation of what is already in excess, which can be harmful.

Vitamin D for instance, fat-soluble, accumulates and becomes toxic in overdose.

Here is what to ask your doctor for, with the exact terms to write on the prescription.

25-OH vitamin D

Too low (< 30 ng/mL) : D3 supplementation, dose adjusted to deficit, recheck after 3 months.

Too high (> 100 ng/mL) : stop all supplementation — risk of hypercalcemia.

Complete blood count + ferritin

Ferritin too low (< 30 µg/L) : increase heme iron intake (red meat), consume with vitamin C, avoid tea and coffee around meals. If anemia is confirmed : medical consultation.

Ferritin too high (> 200 µg/L in men) : may indicate inflammation or hemochromatosis — mandatory medical consultation.

Erythrocyte magnesium

Important : don't simply write « magnesium » — that gives serum magnesium, far less reliable.

Too low : supplement with magnesium bisglycinate or malate. **Too high** : rare, usually linked to renal insufficiency — medical consultation.

Serum zinc

Too low : increase intake via food (beef, eggs) or moderate supplementation — do not exceed 25–30 mg/day at the risk of creating a copper deficiency.

Too high : reduce or stop any zinc supplementation.

hs-CRP (high-sensitivity)

Important : don't simply write « CRP » — standard CRP is less precise for detecting chronic low-grade inflammation.

Too high (> 3 mg/L chronically) : review recovery, sleep, omega-3, temporarily reduce training volume.

Lipid panel

Total cholesterol, HDL, LDL, triglycerides — available at any standard laboratory.

LDL or triglycerides too high, or HDL too low : review the quality of dietary fats and supplement with omega-3 EPA/DHA.

X. Sleep — The Mirror of Desire

Sleep is the most perfect and brutal illustration of what psychology is — its principles, its dynamics, its power.

Some people focus on what we call in psychology the *real* : if you implement every sleep hygiene recommendation, then you are supposed to have perfect sleep.

That is the logic of the protocol, the recipe, the measurable real. And it is insufficient.

Because if something inside you keeps you from sleeping, you will not sleep — no matter the dark room, perfect temperature, or evening ritual.

Then there are those who focus on the *imaginary* : psychology would work independently of any context, by sheer force of will or positive thinking.

That is the other illusion.

The truth is in the dynamic itself : if you have desire — real desire, the kind that does not negotiate — you will put in place what works for you.

Not the general recommendations of a guide, not a champion's protocol. What has meaning in your history, your becoming, your subjectivity.

That is where the real power of psychology lies — not in the mechanical application of universal rules, but in the discovery of what, for you, serves your desire.

With that desire, one can sleep in the worst conditions. Without it, the best conditions in the world will not be enough.

> *« Sleep is not commanded. It is earned — by the desire of what comes after. »*

That said, the tools exist. And when desire is there, you use them. Not because they guarantee anything — but because they serve the process.

That is exactly the spirit of this program.

Tools at the service of the process

Wake at a fixed time

It is the foundation — already mentioned at the wake-up. It is what anchors everything else.

Total darkness

Melanopsin is sensitive to the slightest photon.

A bedroom that lets light in disrupts melatonin secretion and fragments deep sleep. Shutters, blackout curtains, mask if needed.

Cool temperature

Body temperature must drop to initiate and maintain deep sleep. A bedroom between 17 and 19°C is optimal.

It is counter-intuitive but physiologically established.

No screens in the hour before bed

The blue light from screens activates the ipRGCs — the same cells that serve waking up.

The signal sent to the brain is : *the day continues*. Melatonin is suppressed. Sleep onset is delayed.

No alcohol

Alcohol facilitates sleep onset but destroys sleep quality — it fragments cycles, suppresses REM sleep, and massively reduces nocturnal GH secretion.

It is a direct enemy of recovery and body composition.

Stress management

The number-one factor. Chronically elevated cortisol prevents sleep onset, fragments cycles, reduces deep sleep.

Every elite athlete knows this. Almost no one truly works on it.

That is precisely where supervision on parlaforce.com comes in — work with a specialized psychologist to turn this knowledge into lived experience.

XI. Desire — What Man Is Capable Of

To truly understand what desire is — its functioning, its place, its power — we need a figure. A concrete case. Something that comes up often in therapy and that illustrates with brutal clarity what is at stake.

Take erectile dysfunction.

Faced with that problem, the common thinking is the following : either it's in the head, or it's elsewhere — a physical, organic, medical problem.

This is the worst misunderstanding of psychology one can have. It is even more than that : it is despising human nature.

It is forgetting what man is capable of.

Because there is no such thing as the head detached from the rest.

The psyche is precisely the meeting between language and body. Everything passes through there. Every sensation, every bodily phenomenon — they appear to us, they exist for us, through our psychic system.

There is not, on one side, the body, and on the other, the mind. There is the human, whole, irreducible.

But let us go to the heart of the point.

Those who claim the problem might be elsewhere will say : fatigue, blood pressure, stress, age.

All those things exist. *None of them is an excuse.*

Human nature is that even without sleep, even with blood pressure problems, even with all the problems in the world — if you have desire, you will get hard.

That is human nature. That is what being human is.

« Desire does not negotiate with conditions. It cuts through them. »

And it is exactly the same principle for training and performance.

Fatigue exists. Lack of sleep exists. Injuries exist.

None of them is a sufficient reason — not when desire is fully there.

Desire is an indomitable fire. That is human nature.

Accept nothing less. No compromise.

The limits one believes one is hitting are limits of desire — not limits of the body.

Desire can be trained.

You will say your injuries truly prevent you from reaching your goals. But that does not stop you from trying.

Knife between the teeth. One-way ticket. Bon voyage.

Supervision with a psychologist specialized in strength sports : parlaforce.com

XII. Cortisol — The First Killer of Adaptation

Before talking about recovery, hormones, nutrition — we must talk about cortisol.

Because everything else can be perfectly in place, but if cortisol is chronically elevated, the adaptations do not come.

It is the first killer.

Cortisol is a stress hormone secreted by the adrenal glands.

Acutely — a sprint, a heavy set, an emergency — it is useful, it mobilizes energy.

The problem is *chronic* cortisol. The kind that never really comes back down.

At that level, it directly inhibits protein synthesis, breaks down muscle tissue, suppresses testosterone production, disrupts sleep, and slows recovery.

It methodically cancels everything that training builds.

The main source of chronic cortisol in the modern world is not training.

It is lifestyle. Permanent informational overload, screens, notifications, videos that change every two seconds — all of it keeps the nervous system in a state of low but constant alert.

The body does not distinguish a predator from a feed of short videos. It responds the same way : cortisol.

The prescription is not to flee from life. It is to have activities aligned with your goals — activities that rebuild, not drain.

Meditation

Meditation is not a spiritual practice reserved for those who feel like it. It is a tool of nervous-system regulation. And as such, it has its place in the life of any serious athlete.

What we are talking about here is not guided meditation, not visualization, not any particular technique.

It is simpler and more radical than that : *sit, do nothing, and focus on nothing in particular.*

No phone. No music. No goal. Just be there, without trying to produce anything.

The nervous system needs these windows to come down.

In a world where every spare moment is immediately filled with a stimulus — a notification, a screen, a task — these moments have become so rare they have almost disappeared. And cortisol, itself, does not come down.

Fifteen minutes a day is enough. No need for more to start feeling the effects.

What you will discover is how tense your nervous system was without your realizing it.

And how much that release changes the quality of your sessions, your sleep, and your adaptations.

> *« The athlete who manages his cortisol will progress faster than the one who trains more. »*

XIII. Technique — Positive Phase, Negative Phase

Before talking about active recovery, we must talk about what happens during the session — on every rep.

The positive phase must be performed as hard and as fast as possible.

Imagine there is a punching bag at the end of the movement and you must hit it as hard as possible. That is the intention.

This intention recruits a maximum of muscle fibers and sends a strong nervous signal — that is what produces adaptation, not the sense of « congestion » or « contraction » that is sometimes manufactured.

The negative phase must be controlled — not necessarily slowed.

Controlling does not mean holding back at slow motion for five seconds.

On some exercises, controlling the negative is not even necessary — you can perfectly let your deadlift drop on the negative phase, no progress will be lost.

On others, control is enough. The descent stays mastered, without shock, without bounce. That is all.

Accessory exercises

The trap with accessories is the swing.

On a lateral raise, a curl, an extension — the temptation is to give all your strength from the start of the movement. At that moment, the body uses momentum rather than the targeted muscles.

The result : the load moves, but the targeted muscle barely works.

The method is simple. The first part of the movement is done at 60 % of your strength. No more.

This first part is very short — it is the first centimeters of the movement, just enough to engage the targeted muscles without using momentum.

Once that engagement is achieved — and we are talking about a few centimeters, not half the range of motion — you go to 100 % all the way to the end of the movement.

This nuance changes everything. With it, the accessory truly works what it must work. Without it, you move load without recruiting the target muscle.

« Hit hard, but hit the right place. »

XIV. Active Recovery — Metabolism as a Weapon

Active recovery, beyond the short term, is conditioning. It is metabolism.

Being sedentary will reduce your potential to a shadow — not only your condition, but your very ability to progress, to use the nutrients given to you, to react to training.

Every day : walk for at least 45 minutes.

To intensify, use a weighted vest at 5 to 10 % of bodyweight. Simple. Daily. Inexorable.

On rest days especially, that is the minimum expected. Cardio can be added depending on mood and form.

Moving after meals

Moving the body for 10 to 15 minutes right after eating brings substantial benefits.

Metabolically, this post-meal movement activates glucose uptake by muscle cells without going through insulin. The glycemic peak is flattened, less insulin is secreted, and nutrients are preferentially directed toward muscle tissue rather than adipose tissue.

Digestively, movement stimulates gastric and intestinal motility — digestion is more efficient, comfort better, micronutrient absorption optimized.

It can be walking. But it can equally be mobilizing the areas of the body that need it most for you — the hips if they tend to be tight, the shoulders, the back.

The point is not intense effort : it is simply to *activate* the body. To pull it out of the stillness it would otherwise have stayed in.

Taken alone, this detail seems anecdotal. Cumulated over hundreds of meals in a year, it makes a visible difference — on body composition, on digestion, on daily energy.

Finger extension exercises with elastic bands are reserved for training days — on rest days, you recover.

Many people complain they cannot easily lose fat, cannot easily build muscle.

In reality, they simply have a sluggish metabolism.

By applying the advice in this guide and staying active daily, you improve your metabolism — and with it, your ability to extract the maximum from what you eat and what you do at the session.

The mindset to adopt : replace *I will eat less to create a caloric deficit* with *I will increase my expenditure to create that deficit.*

What we are fighting here is the temptation to do nothing on the pretext of wanting to gain weight.

Effortless victory produces no effect. Potential is found in the battle.

« Effortless victory produces no effect. Potential is found in the battle. »

What follows is the program.

Trust the process. Steady wins the race.

ELITE

PROGRAMMING

How to read, use, and make these programs your own.

I. The Essence of Training

I personally progressed more in 8 months than in 8 years applying this guide.

Not because before I was only working at half-effort — at certain periods I was training far more than today in terms of hours per week.

Simply because now I fully apply every aspect of this guide, without overdoing it, without underdoing it. Everything is conscientiously applied.

In a hack squat session, when I start to hurt, I know that is when the work begins.

The reps that count are from there on.

To make the rest clear, imagine a coach interested in all kinds of speculation as they all are, but who does not ask his athlete : *are you sufficiently hydrated ?*

The athlete may eventually answer : yes, leave me alone with that, I know how to drink, I am not paying you for this.

And if — precisely if — the athlete pushes back at that moment, that is particularly important.

He will be able to learn the nature of training : putting the work back to the bench again and again. Hydration, like everything else, is never settled.

You go back to it again and again, without vanity, without frustration.

A coach who does not ask that — it is not that he is doing his work poorly. It is that he is not doing it at all.

That is the difference between hundreds of thousands of intermediate athletes in the world and the few elite athletes.

Remembering why you do what you do. Always.

II. The Programs

L'Archange Expurgateur : complete hypertrophy and strength, the entire body is worked, nothing is left aside.

Le Bras Armé des Dieux : a specific grip program for forearm and hand hypertrophy and strength.

III. How to Read and Use These Programs

This chapter explains how the four programs of this guide work.

It is divided in two parts : *tailored*, for those who want to fully appropriate the system and adapt it to their reality, and *off-the-shelf*, for those who want to start without asking questions.

Tailored

The rep range is the spine of progression.

Each exercise has its own — for example 4–6 for big lifts, 6–8 for accessories.

The goal is to progress within that range with a given weight, then increase the load when you reach the top.

When you start a new exercise or a new block, aim to be near the top of your range, even above.

Starting a 4–6 already stuck at 4 reps in week 1 means jumping with no momentum.

If on the contrary you find yourself doing more than the top of the range on your back-offs or accessories at the start of a block — that is excellent news.

Don't force the load to fit inside the range. Let that margin shrink naturally over the weeks.

Strength vs Hypertrophy

First of all, a word about the term « intensity ».

A load is not intense because it is heavy — it is intense because it is *close to failure.*

85 % of 1RM for a single rep is not intense, because you are far from failure.

Conversely, 70 % of 1RM for a set of 15 looks lighter on paper, but it is in reality far more intense, because you are near failure on the last rep.

That is the only meaning of the word intensity this guide accepts.

When we speak of intensity, we speak of *proximity to failure* — not of the number on the bar.

A popular and stubborn belief, even among coaches, holds that strength is built at high intensity — every set pushed near failure.

That is false.

Recent research is unambiguous : in strength, training at high or moderate intensity yields the same gains.

And since they are equivalent, it is obviously preferable to stay at moderate intensity — because that allows you to raise *volume* and *frequency*, which are what really matter for strength.

Hypertrophy follows the opposite logic.

It is *intensity* that prevails — sets must be pushed near failure to generate the maximum mechanical stimulus.

Volume remains useful, but with rapidly diminishing returns, because what becomes the limiting factor is recovery. You cannot multiply sets to failure indefinitely without the nervous system and tissues paying the bill.

These two logics trace a dividing line at which the athlete, at some point, must take his stand.

The program is a frame : it does not decide for you which attribute to push, nor when to push it. That decision is yours.

If it is *strength* you want to gain in this block, it is volume you must raise — keeping intensity at moderate distance from failure, so you can absorb that volume and distribute it through frequency.

If it is *hypertrophy* you want to push, it is the opposite : you must keep volume at the *minimum effective* — no more, no less — and raise intensity until the sets truly bite.

The Minimum Effective

The *minimum effective* is one of the most important notions in training, and one of the most misunderstood.

It is not the minimum you accept to do out of laziness.

It is the smallest dose that still produces the targeted adaptation — not one rep less, but not one rep more either.

Any volume beyond costs recovery without earning further progress. Any volume below triggers nothing.

The minimum effective is the bare essential — the just-right amount of stimulus that forces the body to adapt, while leaving the resources untouched for that adaptation to take place.

In hypertrophy, it is what allows you to push intensity without recovery collapsing.

In strength, it is what you leave behind — because volume *is* the main lever.

Practical conclusion

— To get *stronger* : volume first, distributed in frequency, on loads that of course must be heavy, but staying at greater distance from failure than for hypertrophy.

— To *build muscle* : volume at the minimum effective, but sets that truly bite, taken near failure, with plenty of recovery between sessions.

This distinction explains why a strength athlete can progress training 4 or 5 times a week on the same movements, while a bodybuilder attempting the same frequency taking every set to failure would burn out in two blocks.

« The program is a frame. The decision is the athlete's. »

Volume and Intensity — capacities, not numbers

When we say to aim for the most volume possible, the important word is *possible*.

Not imaginable, not ideal, not what you read in a pro programmer's sheet — possible. For you, today.

In the beginning, the most volume possible may be 2 sets on an exercise. That is all. And that is fine.

The work then is to raise your capacity to absorb volume — so that your « possible » becomes 3 sets, then 4, then more.

Useful volume is never an absolute number. It is the upper limit of what your body can absorb and draw progress from.

The same principle applies to intensity.

If we forgot it, we would spend every week at RPE 10. But our capacity fluctuates constantly — between blocks, between weeks, sometimes even between sessions.

So programming must be calibrated to that fluctuation, not deny it.

Concretely, within a block, sessions begin at RPE 7, even RPE 8.

At the level of sensation, at that moment, it may feel like RPE 10 — it is hard, it weighs, you feel like you have given. But you are far from it, because you do not yet have the capacity to deliver a true RPE 10.

Then week after week, you raise intensity. Capacity rises with it.

And when you reach the maximum your body can tolerate within the current block : deload, and start again — with a baseline capacity one notch higher than before.

That is the movement that produces progress. Not systematic RPE 10. Not raw « always more ».

The capacity to push hard is built by respecting the fact that it is built.

Common scenarios — these are only examples, others exist.

Case 1 — Smooth progression

Week	*Top set*	*Situation*
1	100kg × 6	Starting at top of range
2	102.5kg × 6	Move up directly
3	105kg × 6	Continue
4	107.5kg × 6	Continue
5	85kg × 4	Deload

Case 2 — Load goes up but reps drop temporarily

Week	*Top set*	*Situation*
1	100kg × 6	Start
2	102.5kg × 5	Load up, reps down
3	105kg × 4	Continue
4	105kg × 6	Top of range reached
5	107.5kg × 4-5	Restart
6	85kg × 4	Deload

Case 3 — Nothing moves

If 3 weeks at the same weight without any progress — neither rep nor load — you go down and restart from a more solid base.

Some exercises take time to click. That is the process.

Tracking progression — everywhere

On the big lifts — deadlift, squat, hack squat, bench — progression is easy to see. The load goes up, you notice, it is rewarding.

The risk is to give it all your attention and neglect the rest.

You must track progression on every exercise, no exception.

Including the small accessories — lateral raises, curls, extensions — where progress doesn't look rewarding because you won't add 50 kilos to them.

That is precisely where the most underestimated lever of the guide hides.

Take an example. Your lateral raises are at 10 kg. Going to 12 kg looks trivial — two kilos, barely something to brag about.

Except in proportion, it is exactly the same gap as between a 300 kg deadlift and a 360 kg deadlift.

Nobody would say a deadlift going from 300 to 360 is insignificant.

And yet, that is exactly the same progression — but everyone neglects it on accessories.

It is this diffuse progression, everywhere at once, that makes the difference between a stagnating physique and one that transforms.

Seek progress at all costs — even if it is just one more rep on a set of 20.

One more rep today. Two in two weeks. And in two months, you add 2 kg on the bar.

Over a year, these accumulations literally transform the physique — in a way no big lift alone can produce.

Note everything. A previous session compared to the next must show *something* that moved — a rep, a kilo, a form improvement, an extra set.

« Great progress is an accumulation of small ones. »

Deload

The right moment is generally between week 4 and week 7, just before the plateau hits — when progression slows, not when it stops.

Strengthening

Before each session, specific strengthening.

Upper body : rotator cuff rotation with band, low-elbow band face pulls, band pull-aparts.

Lower body : cossack squat with kettlebell or front-held dumbbell.

1 to 2 sets until you feel a slight burn — stop there.

It is silent volume, not intense effort. Its role is to prepare the joints and accumulate gentle work over time.

For grip-specific training, strengthening must include a grip exercise (gripper or ring grip), a finger-extension exercise (elastic finger band), and a thumb exercise (egg thumb).

1 to 2 light sets until slight burn.

Dynamic stretching

Stretching dynamically, ideally every day, for 10 to 30 minutes, brings substantial benefits : preserved range of motion, improved movement quality, injury prevention, and active recovery between sessions.

Most athletes stretch right before their session, as part of a long structured warm-up.

This is not my approach. My approach is to do that work outside of sessions — to be ready at any moment.

Conditioning is built over time, and so is the capacity to be ready.

Instead of taking 30 minutes just to touch an empty bar, the goal is to have a body that responds, immediately.

For the movements themselves, I refer you to my YouTube channel — I have dedicated videos on the topic.

Number of sets

You always start at the minimum effective.

Adding a set is tempting — it gives the impression of doing more, therefore advancing. But added volume is useless as long as the other fundamentals of the guide are not in place.

Before adding a set, run through the following questions.

SHOULD I ADD A SET?

Are you sleeping enough?
- NO → *Fix sleep first.*
- YES ↓

Are you hitting your macros?
- NO → *Fix the diet first.*
- YES ↓

Are you well hydrated?
- NO → *Hydrate first.*
- YES ↓

Are you walking 45 min daily?
- NO → *Restore the walking.*
- YES ↓

Is your stress under control?
- NO → *Work on stress management.*
- YES ↓

Has progress truly stalled?
- NO → *Keep current volume.*
- YES ↓

YES — Add a set.

If progress stalls again after this first added set, run through the same grid before adding another.

You don't add volume on principle. You add it when everything else is already in place and that is the only lever left.

Peaks — optional

Peaking is not mandatory.

You can spend your whole life progressing on 4–6 reps without ever peaking and continue progressing indefinitely.

If however you want to explore that dimension, you can occasionally take 1 to 2 big lifts on 3, 2, or 1-rep sets at maximum load.

Not before completing 1 to 2 blocks of pure progression.

Never all the big lifts in peak simultaneously — one, maximum two. The others continue normal progression.

Alternative Exercises

The exercises recommended in this program are recommendations, not obligations.

If you want to substitute one exercise for another, here are the validated alternatives for each slot.

Keep an exercise as long as possible. The idea of these programs is to put the work back to the bench again and again — not to reinvent everything every block.

Only change an exercise when you have done two consecutive blocks without the slightest progress.

And even then, ask yourself before changing : why is it not progressing ?

It is not necessarily the exercise itself. It is often recovery, nutrition, sleep, stress.

Changing exercises to escape a plateau is telling yourself a story.

Main exercise	*Alternatives*
Incline bench	Dips — Incline press machine — Swiss bar incline press — Incline DB press

Vertical pulling	Pronated pull-up — Supinated pull-up — Bilateral lat pulldown — Neutral-grip pulldown
Hack squat	Pendulum squat — Back squat
Lunges	Bulgarian split squats
Bent-over row	Chinese row — Chest-supported row — T-bar row — Barbell row

Trust the process. Steady wins the race.

IV. Injuries

There are three types of pain or injury. Knowing how to distinguish them changes everything in how you keep progressing despite them.

Type 1 — Passing pain

Pain that requires no adjustment and passes on its own.

Sometimes it can be spectacular — you may feel like you just tore something.

You stay in type 1 in the sense that, the next day, you can go back to training.

It passes « on its own », even if it takes time. It hinders neither the execution of movements nor their intensity.

Type 2 — Pain that lingers

The pain stays and movements are affected.

However, by reducing intensity, you can still train.

Regressing and restarting progression allows the body to recover and heal.

Type 3 — Injury demanding adaptation

The pain remains despite regression.

You must then adapt training to allow the body to heal, putting specific exercises in place.

For example, if squatting becomes impossible — even bodyweight — you must find a way to work the area to allow a return to strengthening.

The solution is always strengthening

Tension, pain, injury — it is always a sign of weakness.

The solution is therefore always the same : *strengthening.*

Always prioritize range of motion first. The first work is to recover the range fully ; only then comes intensity.

If the athlete has weaknesses — shoulders, wrists, others — he must implement specific strengthening to avoid suffering for it in his progression.

Tendon work

Tendons strengthen particularly well with static effort and tempo — that is, maximum tension at maximum stretch.

For example, holding the bar in the bottom position of a bench press, with a load such that the athlete cannot move it and can push as hard as he wants without the bar moving.

Holding the effort for 5 to 15 seconds constitutes one set.

V. Horse Cocking

Exercises must be done with the goal of adding load.

What changes the physique, what builds strength, is load. Not the sensation, not the impression, not the « mind-muscle connection » — load.

The bodybuilding trap to avoid at all costs is trying to « feel » the muscle, « feel » the load, at the price of using less weight.

This pursuit of pure sensation pushes the athlete to bridle himself, to choose comfortable weights, to perform movements that « speak » well to the muscles but never force them to become stronger.

You must allow yourself a slight blurring of technique to push what matters most : intensity, load.

That is horse cocking : cheating just enough to lift more than you could with perfect execution.

Our favorite exercise for horizontal pulling is the bent-over row, because it allows you to « overload » the exercise.

It allows you to exceed what you could deliver on a simple chest-supported row. The trunk works, the hip helps slightly, and the load lifted far exceeds what would be possible in strict isolation.

Of course, you must not lose sight of the movement and start doing something else. It must remain a pull where you fully use the targeted muscles.

The idea is not to turn a row into a dynamic deadlift.

The logic : you start a block with clean technique, you allow it to degrade slightly as load goes up week after week to become stronger, and in the next block you give yourself clean technique on a load you were unable to handle before.

Clean technique is not an absolute — it is a starting point that gets reconquered at every strength tier.

ELITE

L'ARCHANGE EXPURGATEUR

L'Archange Expurgateur trains the main grip strength exercises, the competition lifts, accompanied by full-body strength and hypertrophy.

Four training days per week.

Day 1

Exercise	*Sets*	*Reps*
Axle deadlift	1	4 to 6
Thumbless row	1	4 to 6
Thumbless pronated curl	1	6 to 8
Incline bench	1	4 to 6
Close-grip incline bench	2	6 to 8
Fly press*	2	6 to 8
French press	2	8 to 15
Triceps pushdown	2	8 to 15

** Lying fly press : the elbows may bend, but aim to keep them away from the body at the bottom of the movement.*

If you don't have a axle bar, do fat grips on an olympic bar

Day 2

Exercise	*Sets*	*Reps*
Deficit deadlift / deadlift no straps no hook	1	4 to 6
Deficit deadlift / deadlift with straps or hook	1	4 to 6
Stiff-leg deadlift	1	4 to 6
Thumbless row	1	6 to 8

Leg curl	2	8 to 15
Face pull	2	8 to 15

Day 3

Exercise	*Sets*	*Reps*
Saxon deadlift	1	4 to 6
Saxon upright row	1	6 to 8
Saxon pronated curl	1	6 to 8
Saxon supinated curl	1	6 to 8
Hack squat	2	6 to 15
Back squat	1	6 to 8
Walking lunges	1	6 to 15
Ab crunches	2	—

If you don't have a saxon bar, do pinch plate lifts

Day 4

Exercise	*Sets*	*Reps*
Unilateral lat pulldown — fat grip	1	4 to 6
Unilateral lat pulldown — fingertip	1	4 to 6
Unilateral lat pulldown — straps	2	6 to 8
Bent-over row — fat grip	1	4 to 6
Bent-over row — fingertip	1	4 to 6

Bent-over row — straps	2	6 to 8
Curl	2	6 to 15
Single-arm preacher hammer curl	2	6 to 15

Note on elbow flexion

Given the high amount of elbow flexion in this program, I recommend super-setting each curl with a triceps exercise.

The super-set balances the load on the elbow by alternating flexor and extensor work — which protects the joint over the long term.

Given the volume of these movements, do not chase intensity too quickly on them. Progression here must be slow — accumulate work with margin before truly pushing.

ELITE

LE BRAS ARMÉ DES DIEUX

Program

Le Bras Armé des Dieux is a list of accessory exercises for grip strength, hypertrophy, and health.

Not a rigid program — a toolbox.

Several ways to use it.

You can scatter these exercises through the week, in your usual sessions. You can group them into a single session per week.

If you truly want to become Le Bras Armé des Dieux, I advise high frequency : doing the whole list 2 to 4 times per week.

The list

— Lateral raises with pinched plates : 6 to 15 reps
— Curl with pinched plates : 6 to 15 reps
— Lateral raises fat grip thumbless : 6 to 15 reps
— Pronated curl fat grip thumbless : 6 to 15 reps
— Wrist extension (recommended with an Andrieux roller) : 12 to 40 reps
— Finger roll superset with wrist flexion : 8 to 15 reps
— Fingertip shrug : 6 to 15 reps
— Thumb flexion (recommended thumb grip press + hand training egg) : beyond the burn
— Finger extender : beyond the burn

For thumb flexion and finger extender, don't count reps : just go beyond the burning sensation.

These exercises mainly strengthen tendons and ligaments, and bring blood to the area to support active recovery.

Advice

Strength on these movements is built over time.

Do not try to go to failure.

Keep margin for a long time — that is what first builds tissue resilience, which is the foundation on which strength comes to rest. Not the other way around.

Step by step, raise the loads. Raise intensity. But slowly.

Forearms, hands, fingers, ligaments — these are structures that adapt more slowly than the rest of the body.

Skipping steps here is a guaranteed way to earn a tendinopathy that will cost you months of stagnation.

Start with a single set per exercise. One. As long as you progress at that volume, keep that volume.

If you hit a plateau, raise volume very gradually — one extra set at a time, on one exercise at a time. Never all at once.

The logic is the same as the rest of the guide : capacity is built.

Do not skip steps.

Strong grip comes to those who accept that it is built slowly.